**Figure 82:** Dominican Square, now an open-air market, directly above the Romanesque Cellar. The Market Hall in the background, on the left. (Narodowy Instytut Dziedzictwa, Agnieszka Makowska)

**Figure 83:** The Romanesque Cellar, part of the 13th-century monastery, now the branch of the Archaeological Museum in Gdańsk. (Narodowy Instytut Dziedzictwa, Agnieszka Makowska)

with a brick vestibule have also been discovered as remains of the first monastic complex. In 2009 it was decided to open the cellar to the public. To make it possible, a concrete structure was built above the cellar. The underground archaeological open-air museum, a branch of the Archaeological Museum in Gdańsk, was open to the public in 2015 (Figs.82 & 83). Visitors are led through a light and sound show. There is also a film about the history of the cellars, full of visual reconstructions of the church and monastery through the ages.

## Assessing significance – methods and results

The discovery of relics under the Market Hall and bazaar in Dominican Square was sensational, but required difficult decisions to be made, with a huge amount of time and money behind them. The renovation of the Market Hall, which began in 2001, was planned to take 15 months. As a result of the archaeological discoveries relating to the Church of St Nicholas, the Voivodship Monuments Preservation Officer had altered recommendations for the restorative of the Hall. Changes were made to the interior renovation project to expose the discovered foundations. In the end, the renewal work took 5 years.

The Romanesque Cellar was discovered in 2006. Initially, it was decided that after the research, the cellar would be filled in. This decision was met with protests from the archaeological, art history and conservation communities. It was argued that the parts of the vaults that had survived would most likely be destroyed when they were filled in again. The criteria for assessing significance of the relics were outlined in a letter to the General Monument Preservation Officer. It was emphasised that it is the only surviving brick late-Romanesque building in Gdańsk. The criteria used were local uniqueness and relevance to the local community. It is also valuable for its historical and symbolic value, as the only monument of its kind from pre-Teutonic Gdańsk and as an object associated with the Dominican Order, whose history is closely interwoven with that of the city. The cellar and the remains of the first church exposed in the market hall form an architectural complex. As stated in the letter, both should be made available to visitors for their educational and aesthetic value. The good state of preservation is a starting point in confirming the importance of the discovery. In the end, the General Monument Preservation Officer intervened, and it was decided to open the cellar to the public. It took several years to prepare the monument for its role as a museum, including the reconstruction of damaged parts of the walls and ceiling, conservation and groundwater protection. The costs of the project were shared by the City of Gdańsk, the local government of the Pomeranian Voivodship, the Archaeological Museum in Gdańsk and the Minister of Culture and National Heritage.

## Conclusions

The present and the future constantly meet the past in the centres of historic cities. In such places, it is the past that forms the identity of the city. Wise dialogue with the space of historic cities can further their branding or visual identity. Its past gives the town a unique character that could be very attractive to tourists. It strengthens the bonds between residents and unites the community.

Survey on the knowledge and awareness of Poles about the archaeological heritage, carried out in 2020, shows that, according to the vast majority of respondents (98%-99%), archaeological heritage is a testimony to our history and an important source of knowledge for future generations. This heritage allows the inhabitants to feel proud of where they live (95%), which they consider to be unique (96%). As many as 83% of respondents were of the opinion that archaeological sites in their area could be of economic or tourist value. This should be an important voice when assessing the significance of the archaeological relics. It's worth knowing that respondents would most often like to take part in guided tours and archaeology-related displays, which fits in well with the solution proposed for the Romanesque Cellar.

It is essential to survey and record archaeological features in advance, using non-intrusive methods. This includes the analysis of archival maps, photographs and documents, especially in historic towns. This will allow time and money to be secured for detailed research, thorough documentation and conservation, as well as significance assessment and making decision. This requires a multi-disciplinary approach, involving not only archaeologists and heritage managers, but also local authorities, town planners, architects, engineers and hydrologists (to predict the impact of the decision on the surrounding area, for example on neighbouring buildings or changes in water levels).

When deciding whether or not to protect an archaeological monument, the utmost care needs to be taken. The destruction of the archaeological relics is irreversible, and excavation research is an experiment that cannot be repeated. And it is a decision on behalf of future generations, not just today's needs. The social benefits of an archaeological site are an important consideration before a decision is made. The example of Gdańsk shows that it is well worth the effort.

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